ESCITALOPRAM

QT prolongation
Well tolerated

CHEMICAL NAME (S)-1-[3-(dimethylamino)propyl]-1-(4-fluorophenyl)-1,3-dihydro-2-benzofuran-5-carbonitrile (oxalate)

CLASS Selective serotonin reuptake inhibitor (S-enantiomer of citalopram)

TRADE NAMES Cipralex · Lexapro · Escitalo · Esipram

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Major depression.
- Generalised anxiety disorder, panic disorder, social anxiety.
- OCD.

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** once daily with or without food.

DOSAGES

- **Adult:** 10 mg once daily; max 20 mg.
- **Panic:** start 5 mg for 1 week.
- **Elderly >65 / hepatic impairment:** start 5 mg, max 10 mg.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 1–4 weeks.
- Metabolised by CYP2C19, 3A4, 2D6.
- **t½:** 27–32 h.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Monitor mood, suicidality, Na^+ (elderly).
- ECG if cardiac risk.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Most selective **5-HT reuptake** inhibitor; allosteric binding enhances effect.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Nausea, headache.
- Insomnia, fatigue, sweating.
- Sexual dysfunction.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- QT prolongation (dose-dependent).
- Hyponatraemia.
- Suicidality; serotonin syndrome; bleeding.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Long QT; QT-prolonging drugs; MAOIs; pimozide.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **QT drugs:** avoid.
- **Omeprazole, cimetidine:** ↑ levels.
- **Serotonergic drugs, anticoagulants:** as SSRIs.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Takes 2–4 weeks to work.
- Taper to stop.
- Report palpitations, worsening mood.

KEY POINTS

- S-citalopram — potent, well-tolerated SSRI.
- QT prolongation.
- 10 mg; max 20 mg (10 mg elderly).
- Depression and anxiety.